BJP's Mission 50 in the South

With the BJP targeting a win in 370 seats on its own this election compared to the 303 it won in 2019 and hoping to cross, along with its National Democratic Alliance (NDA) partners, a mammoth 400, the saffron party not only needs to retain its previous tally but add to it. Drawing a blank in the 85 seats as it did last time will instantly bring down the number of winnable seats to 458 from 543. The party will then need a strike rate of 87 per cent, a formidable task by all means. The BJP and NDA will have to add another 20 seats to their 2019 tally of 29 to make '*char sau paar*' a reality. Hence Mission 50, the objective of their southern assault.

Tamil Nadu remains key in the BJP's plans to get the 20 additional seats. Join the sundry dots, and you realise PM Modi and his party have been systematically working to win over the state ever since their second term began. Thus, in October 2019, the PM chose the coastal tourist city of Mamallapuram for his summit meeting with Chinese president Xi Jinping, where they chalked out a "Chennai Connect" to improve relations. The prime minister even dressed the part on the occasion, wearing a *veshti* (dhoti), white shirt and a brocade *thundu* (scarf) as he proudly took Xi around at an exhibition that showcased Tamil culture at the summit venue. Then, while inaugurating the new Parliament building in September 2023, Modi installed the *sengol*, a gold-plated silver sceptre that a Tamil organisation had gifted India's first prime minister Jawaharlal Nehru on the eve of Independence and which had found its way to the Allahabad Museum. More recently, at the Kashi Tamil Sangamam event in December 2023 in Varanasi, the prime minister made it a point to have his speech translated simultaneously into Tamil using artificial intelligence.

Symbolism apart, Modi, along with home minister Amit Shah and party president J.P. Nadda, also devised a concrete game plan to revamp the Tamil Nadu unit of the BJP. It began with installing the feisty former IPS officer K. Annamalai as the president of the state unit—at 39, the youngest ever of its party chiefs in the state. No one understood the brief better than him, or executed it with more systematic precision. After the DMK swept the 2021 assembly election, the BJP, which won only four of the state's 234 seats, began to seriously rethink its alliance with the AIADMK. Annamalai, ever the able lieutenant, embarked on an aggressive campaign not just against the ruling DMK in the course of his statewide padayatra, but also the AIADMK, the party's alliance partner, which eventually ended in a breakdown of communication. By September 2023, the BJP got what it wanted—the AIADMK broke off its alliance with the saffron side, to preserve its Dravidian identity.

Stitching Alliances

Free of the AIADMK, the BJP took the high-risk decision of forming its own alliance in Tamil Nadu and heading it, a first for it. The party is now contesting 19 seats on its own—14 more than in 2019—and has given the remaining 20 to alliance partners. The BJP's calculation is that with AIADMK heading for a meltdown, it has a chance to emerge as the principal opposition in the state. The fact that the prime minister himself has made more than seven trips to Tamil Nadu since January, and addressed over 11 rallies, signals how much the BJP is willing to invest in the state to achieve its objectives.

As RSS ideologue S. Gurumurthy, the current editor of the legendary Tamil political weekly *Thuglak,* points out, "The AIADMK vote bank consists of both anti-DMK votes at the state level and anti-Congress ones at the national level. So, any meltdown within the party could lead to the BJP gaining from it and emerging as the prime challenger to the DMK." Gurumurthy

THE DMK AND STALIN-LED SPA WILL CERTAINLY BE NO WALKOVER ESPECIALLY AS THE ALLIANCE IS GETTING ITS ACT TOGETHER, AND MAKING THINGS DIFFICULT FOR THE BJP



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